Joe's Meal Pack

Tuesday Oct 20 to Wednesday Nov 4, 2026. Part 1: the plan and prep. Part 2: recipes.

Your gear: Instant Pot (pressure cook or slow cook), Samsung oven with Air Fry mode, microwave, a skillet, and a sheet pan. An instant-read thermometer makes every recipe here easier and is worth the few bucks if you don't have one.

Part 1: The Meal Plan

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Recipes
Tue Oct 20			Hot ready-to-eat deli from the Walmart order: ranch-seasoned jumbo wings, chicken spicy mustard wrap, pepperoni and cheese turnover	R1
Wed Oct 21		Leftover deli hot chicken with oven hash browns	Instant Pot pulled pork over loaded hash browns with habanero jack and corn *(start the pork today)*	R1, R2, R3, R4
Thu Oct 22		Pulled pork quesadillas	Jack's pizzas with the kids (2 Original Thin pepperoni + 1 sausage; 1 pepperoni left over). *Cook IP shredded chicken today.*	R5, R6, R7
Fri Oct 23 (gf over)		The extra Jack's pepperoni pizza	Cheese tortellini in homemade alfredo, cheesy garlic bread, seasoned chicken breast for gf	R6, R9, R10, R11
Sat Oct 24 (gf)	Scrambled eggs, hash browns, sausage links	Leftover tortellini alfredo and garlic bread	Baked potato bar: broccoli, cheese, butter, sour cream, a little shredded chicken on the side	R2, R12, R13, R15, R16
Sun Oct 25 (gf)	Kodiak pancakes and sausage links	Leftover baked potatoes	Cook all 5 thick pork chops medium rare. Eat 1 with corn. Cool and freeze 4 individually.	R13, R14, R16, R17
Mon Oct 26 (work)		Deli sandwich (packed ahead)	Pork chop reheated from frozen in microwave + hash browns	R19, R18, R2
Tue Oct 27 (work)		Deli sandwich	Pork chop reheated from frozen + broccoli	R19, R18, R16
Wed Oct 28 (work)		Deli sandwich	Pork chop reheated from frozen + corn	R19, R18, R16
Thu Oct 29 (work)		Deli sandwich	Pork chop reheated from frozen + hash browns (or any side)	R19, R18, R2
Fri Oct 30 (work)		Deli sandwich	Buffalo shredded chicken quesadillas with ranch	R19, R5, R8

Sat Oct 31		Red Baron personal pizza (or another freezer pizza)	Oven-baked hot wings with ranch and blue cheese	R6, R20, R8
Sun Nov 1		Pulled pork nachos with pepper jack	Burgers on pretzel buns with oven hash browns	R21, R22, R2
Mon Nov 2 (work)		Deli sandwich	3-cheese chicken skillet bag meal (follow bag)	R19, R24
Tue Nov 3 (work)		Deli sandwich	BBQ pulled pork quesadillas	R19, R5
Wed Nov 4 (work, payday)		Deli sandwich	Buffalo shredded chicken over a baked potato	R19, R23, R8, R15

Snacks and drinks: Utz Pub Mix, Reese's, Baja Blast, a Monster a day, Svedka.

Prep Timeline

Right away (Tue Oct 20, when the order is put away)

- **Freeze now:** the 1 lb ground beef (needed Nov 1), the pretzel buns (needed Nov 1), and half the Bunny bread if it won't last to Nov 4.
- **Check dates:** Tyson fresh chicken breasts are for Fri Oct 23. If the use-by date is before Friday, freeze them now and move to the fridge Wed night. Lunchmeat is for Oct 26 to Nov 4; open one pack at a time (opened packs last 3 to 5 days). If any unopened pack expires before you'll get to it, freeze it now.
- Pork shoulder stays in the fridge for tomorrow. Pork chops, wings, frozen chicken breasts stay frozen.

Wed Oct 21: Pulled pork day (R3)

- Start the pork by early afternoon (about 2.5 hours total with natural release; 8 to 10 hours if slow cooking, so start in the morning).
- Portion when shredded: 1 fridge container for tonight and Thu lunch quesadillas. Then freezer bags labeled: **"Nov 1 nachos"** (about 1 to 1.5 cups) and **"Nov 3 BBQ quesadillas"** (about 1 to 1.5 cups). Bag any extra in 1 lb portions for later.

Thu Oct 22: Shredded chicken day (R7)

- Cook the 2.5 lb frozen chicken breasts in the Instant Pot. No thawing needed.
- Portion: small fridge container for Sat potato bar. Freezer bags labeled: **"Oct 30 Buffalo quesadillas"** (about 1.5 cups) and **"Nov 4 Buffalo potato"** (about 1 cup). Bag any extra.

Sun Oct 25: Pork chop day (R17)

- Cook all 5 chops. Eat 1. Cool the other 4, wrap each one, bag, label, freeze.

Thaw-the-night-before reminders

Move to fridge on	What	For
Fri Oct 23 night (or Sat morning at the latest)	All 5 pork chops (thick chops need about 24 hours)	Sun Oct 25 dinner

Sun Oct 25 to Wed Oct 28 nights (optional)	Next day's cooked pork chop. Not required, it reheats from frozen, but thawed reheats more evenly.	Mon to Thu dinners
Thu Oct 29 night	Shredded chicken bag "Oct 30"; GV wing sections (4 lb needs about 24 to 36 hours)	Fri Oct 30 dinner; Sat Oct 31 dinner
Sat Oct 31 night	Pulled pork bag "Nov 1"; ground beef; pretzel buns (counter)	Sun Nov 1 lunch and dinner
Mon Nov 2 night	Pulled pork bag "Nov 3"	Tue Nov 3 dinner
Tue Nov 3 night	Shredded chicken bag "Nov 4"	Wed Nov 4 dinner

Forgot to thaw a bag? Set the sealed bag in a bowl of cold water for 30 to 60 minutes, or microwave on defrost in short bursts.

Sandwich packing nights

Sun Oct 25 night: pack Mon. Then each work night pack the next day (or pack 2 at a time; see R19).

Day by Day

Tue Oct 20

Dinner: Walmart hot deli: wings, wrap, turnover. Reheat as needed (R1). Refrigerate leftover wings within 2 hours for tomorrow's lunch.

Wed Oct 21

Lunch: Leftover deli wings, reheated (R1), with oven hash browns (R2).
Dinner: Start pulled pork (R3). When it's close, bake hash browns and build loaded hash browns (R4). Portion and freeze pork bags after dinner.

Thu Oct 22

Lunch: Pulled pork quesadillas (R5).
Dinner: Jack's pizzas with the kids: 2 pepperoni + 1 sausage (R6). Keep 1 pepperoni in the freezer for tomorrow.
Also: Instant Pot shredded chicken (R7). Portion and freeze.

Fri Oct 23 (gf over)

Lunch: Extra Jack's pepperoni pizza (R6).
Dinner: Chicken breast in the oven first (R11), then alfredo and tortellini on the stove (R9), garlic bread goes in the oven while the chicken rests (R10). Save leftovers for Sat lunch.
Tonight: move the 5 pork chops to the fridge.

Sat Oct 24 (gf)

Breakfast: Scrambled eggs (R12), hash browns (R2), sausage links (R13).
Lunch: Reheat tortellini alfredo and garlic bread (see Storage table).
Dinner: Baked potato bar (R15) with broccoli (R16) and a little shredded chicken on the side. Bake 2 extra potatoes for Sunday lunch.

Sun Oct 25 (gf)

Breakfast: Kodiak pancakes (R14) and sausage links (R13).
Lunch: Leftover baked potatoes, reheated.
Dinner: All 5 pork chops medium rare (R17). Eat 1 with corn (R16). Freeze 4.
Tonight: pack Monday's sandwich (R19).

Mon Oct 26 to Thu Oct 29 (work)

Lunch: Deli sandwich (R19).
Dinner: 1 pork chop reheated gently in the microwave (R18). Sides rotate: Mon hash browns, Tue broccoli, Wed corn, Thu hash browns (R2, R16).
Thu night: move "Oct 30" chicken bag and the wings to the fridge.

Fri Oct 30 (work)

Lunch: Deli sandwich.
Dinner: Buffalo shredded chicken quesadillas with ranch (R5, R8).

Sat Oct 31

Lunch: Red Baron personal pizza, or another freezer pizza (R6).
Dinner: Oven hot wings, tossed in BWW Honey BBQ or homemade Buffalo, with ranch and blue cheese (R20, R8).
Tonight: move "Nov 1" pork bag and ground beef to the fridge; pretzel buns to the counter.

Sun Nov 1

Lunch: Pulled pork nachos with pepper jack (R21).
Dinner: Skillet burgers on pretzel buns (R22) with oven hash browns (R2).

Mon Nov 2 (work)

Lunch: Deli sandwich.
Dinner: 3-cheese chicken skillet bag, follow the bag (R24).
Tonight: move "Nov 3" pork bag to the fridge.

Tue Nov 3 (work)

Lunch: Deli sandwich.
Dinner: BBQ pulled pork quesadillas (R5).
Tonight: move "Nov 4" chicken bag to the fridge.

Wed Nov 4 (work, payday)

Lunch: Deli sandwich.
Dinner: Buffalo shredded chicken over a baked potato (R23).

Part 2: Recipes

How to use the Samsung Air Fry mode (read once). It cooks somewhere between a real air fryer and regular baking, so these times are a starting point.

- Always preheat fully (wait for the beep). Middle or upper-middle rack.
- Use a foil-lined sheet pan. A wire rack set on the pan (or the Samsung air fry tray) helps the bottoms crisp.
- Single layer, space between pieces. Crowding = steaming, not crisping.
- Tops brown faster than bottoms, so flip or stir halfway.
- Start checking at the low end of the time. Go by the doneness cue and internal temp, not the clock.

Safe internal temps: chicken 165°F (wings are better at 175 to 190°F), ground beef 160°F, pork for shredding 195 to 205°F, sausage 160°F, reheated leftovers 165°F.

R1. Reheating the Walmart Hot Deli Items

- **Hot ranch wings (Freshness Guaranteed):** Eat hot right away. Leftovers: refrigerate within 2 hours. To reheat, Air Fry mode 375°F preheated, wings on a rack over a sheet pan, 8 to 12 min, flip once. Done when sizzling and hot through (165°F). Microwave works in a pinch (1 to 2 min, covered) but the skin goes soft.
- **Marketside chicken spicy mustard wrap:** Made to eat cold. Keep refrigerated until eating.
- **Marketside pepperoni and cheese turnover:** Best in the oven: Air Fry mode 350°F preheated, 8 to 10 min, until the crust is crisp and the cheese is bubbling at the ends. If the top darkens fast, lay foil loosely over it. Microwave shortcut: 45 to 75 seconds (softer crust).

R2. Oven Hash Browns

Serves 2 per half sheet pan. 20 to 30 min.

Ingredients

- Frozen hash browns (about 2 cups shredded, or 4 to 6 patties)
- 1 to 2 Tbsp vegetable or olive oil (or melted butter)
- Salt, pepper, garlic powder, or your favorite seasoning

Steps

1. Preheat oven on Air Fry mode to 425°F. Line a sheet pan with foil and oil it.
2. **Shredded:** spread in a thin, even layer, no thicker than 1/2 inch. Drizzle oil and season. **Patties:** single layer, brush or spray both sides with oil.
3. Cook 10 to 12 min. Flip with a spatula (shredded: flip in sections).
4. Cook another 8 to 12 min. Done when deep golden and crisp at the edges.

Cooking for 1 on a work night: make a half batch, same temp, check a few minutes early.

R3. Instant Pot Pulled Pork

Bone-in Prairie Fresh pork shoulder (6.5 to 10 lb). Makes enough for about 4 to 6 meals. Hands-on 20 min. Total about 2 to 2.5 hours (pressure) or 8 to 10 hours (slow cook).

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder
- Your favorite pork dry rub, about 3 to 4 Tbsp. *Or mix:* 1 Tbsp salt, 1 Tbsp paprika, 2 tsp garlic powder, 2 tsp dried minced onion, 1 tsp black pepper, 1 tsp chili powder (optional: drizzle of maple syrup)
- 1 cup water + 1 tsp Better Than Bouillon chicken base
- 1 Tbsp vegetable oil (if searing)
- BBQ sauce for serving (optional)

Steps

1. **Cut to fit.** Cut the meat into 3 to 5 large chunks (about 2 lb each), cutting around the bone. Trim the thickest outside fat cap if you like. Put the bone in the pot too, it adds flavor. Don't fill past the 2/3 line. If it won't all fit, cook in two batches or use the slow cook method below.
2. **Season.** Pat dry and rub all over with the rub.
3. **Sear (optional, adds flavor).** Saute mode, oil, brown the chunks 2 to 3 min per side in batches. Remove the meat.
4. **Liquid.** Add the water and Better Than Bouillon. Scrape the bottom so nothing is stuck (this prevents the "Burn" warning). Put the trivet in if you have it, then the pork.
5. **Pressure cook on High:** 60 to 75 min for 2 lb chunks. If cooking a bigger whole-ish piece (4 lb+), go 90 to 100 min.
6. **Natural release** at least 15 to 20 min, then release the rest.
7. **Check.** It should pull apart easily with a fork (about 195 to 205°F). If it fights you, pressure cook 10 to 15 more min.
8. **Shred.** Pull out the meat, remove bone and big fat pieces, shred with 2 forks. Skim fat off the liquid and stir a ladle or two of the juice back into the meat so it stays moist.

Slow cook alternative

Same prep. Slow Cook mode, lid on (vent can stay on venting), Low 8 to 10 hours or High 5 to 6 hours, until fork-tender. Shred the same way.

Storage

Fridge 3 to 4 days. Freeze in meal-size bags with a little juice, flat, labeled, up to 2 to 3 months.

R4. Loaded Pulled Pork Hash Browns (Wed Dinner)

Serves 2. Start the hash browns when the pork is on natural release.

Ingredients

- 1 sheet pan of oven hash browns (R2)
- 1.5 to 2 cups hot pulled pork
- 1 cup frozen corn
- 1 cup shredded habanero jalapeno jack
- Toppings: sour cream, BBQ sauce, Mt. Olive candied jalapenos, ranch

Steps

1. Make the hash browns (R2) right on the sheet pan.
2. Microwave the corn with a pat of butter and a pinch of salt, 2 to 3 min, stir.
3. Top the crispy hash browns with pulled pork, corn, then cheese.
4. Back in the oven (Air Fry 425°F) 3 to 5 min, until the cheese melts.
5. Top with sour cream, a drizzle of BBQ sauce, and candied jalapenos.

R5. Skillet Quesadillas (Pulled Pork, BBQ Pulled Pork, Buffalo Chicken)

1 burrito-size quesadilla per person, 2 if hungry. 10 min.

Base ingredients (per quesadilla)

- 1 Mission burrito-size flour tortilla
- 1/2 to 3/4 cup warm filling (see versions)
- 3/4 cup shredded cheese
- 1 tsp butter or oil

Versions

- **Pulled pork (Thu Oct 22):** plain pulled pork, habanero jack, a few chopped candied jalapenos. Dip: BBQ sauce or sour cream.
- **BBQ pulled pork (Tue Nov 3):** toss the pork with 2 to 3 Tbsp BBQ sauce. Habanero jack or provolone. Dip: ranch or extra BBQ.
- **Buffalo chicken (Fri Oct 30):** toss shredded chicken with 2 to 3 Tbsp Buffalo sauce (R8). Half mozzarella, half habanero jack. Dip: ranch (blue cheese also good).

Steps

1. Warm the filling in the microwave, covered, 1 to 2 min (add a splash of water or juice to pork or chicken so it doesn't dry out).
2. Heat a skillet over medium. Add the butter.
3. Lay the tortilla flat. Sprinkle half the cheese over one half, add filling, then the rest of the cheese. Fold over.
4. Cook 2 to 3 min until golden. Flip with a wide spatula, cook 2 to 3 min more until the cheese is fully melted.
5. Rest 1 min, cut into wedges. Chips on the side if you want.

Too dark outside, cheese not melted? Turn heat down to medium-low and cover the pan for a minute.

R6. Frozen Pizzas (Jack's, Red Baron, or Any Freezer Pizza)

1. Follow the box temperature and time. Use regular **Bake** mode for frozen pizza (Air Fry mode can burn the top before the crust is done).
2. Bake directly on the rack for a crisp crust, or on a sheet pan for a softer one.
3. **3 Jack's at once (Thu):** use 2 racks, swap racks and turn the pizzas halfway, and add 2 to 4 min. Or bake 2, then the third while you eat.
4. Done when cheese is bubbling and the crust edge is golden. Rest 2 min before cutting.
5. **Red Baron personal pizza (Sat Oct 31):** follow the box (oven, or microwave with the crisping tray if the box has one). Don't have it? Any freezer pizza, follow its box.

R7. Instant Pot Shredded Chicken from Frozen

2.5 lb frozen chicken breasts. Makes about 5 to 6 cups. Total about 45 min. No thawing.

Ingredients

- 2.5 lb frozen chicken breasts
- 1 cup water + 1 tsp Better Than Bouillon chicken base
- 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp dried minced onion, 1/2 tsp salt, 1/2 tsp pepper (or a dry rub you like)

Steps

1. Stir the bouillon into the water in the pot. Put in the trivet if you have it.
2. Add the frozen breasts in a single layer as much as possible. If they're frozen together in a block, try to break them apart (run under warm water for a minute).
3. Sprinkle seasoning on top.
4. Pressure cook on High: **12 to 15 min** for separate breasts, **20 to 25 min** if frozen in a solid block.
5. Natural release 10 min, then release the rest.
6. Check the thickest piece: 165°F, no pink. If not there, pressure cook 3 to 5 more min.
7. Shred with 2 forks (or a hand mixer on low, fast). Stir in a few spoons of the cooking liquid.

Storage

Fridge 3 to 4 days. Freeze in labeled meal-size bags with a splash of liquid, up to 2 to 3 months.

R8. Homemade Buffalo Sauce

About 3/4 cup. Enough for 2 lb wings or 2 to 3 meals of chicken.

- 1/2 cup of your hot sauce
- 1/3 cup (about 5 Tbsp) butter
- Pinch of garlic powder (optional: 1 tsp honey mustard or a squeeze of maple syrup to round it out)

1. Melt the butter in a microwave-safe bowl, 30 to 45 sec.
2. Whisk in the hot sauce and garlic powder until smooth.
3. Hotter: more hot sauce. Milder: more butter.

Keeps in the fridge 1 to 2 weeks. It firms up cold; microwave 15 to 20 sec and whisk.

R9. Cheese Tortellini in Homemade Alfredo

One bag frozen cheese tortellini (about 19 to 25 oz). Serves 2 for dinner + 2 for Sat lunch. 20 min.

Ingredients

- 1 bag frozen cheese tortellini
- 6 Tbsp Land O Lakes butter
- 1 Tbsp wet minced garlic
- 2 cups heavy cream
- 1.5 cups grated parmesan
- Salt, black pepper, pinch of garlic powder
- Whole milk, as needed to thin

Steps

1. Big pot of salted water to a boil. Cook tortellini per the bag (usually 3 to 5 min, they float when done). Save 1/2 cup pasta water, then drain.
2. While the water heats: in a large skillet or pot over medium-low, melt the butter. Add garlic, stir 1 min. Don't let it brown.
3. Add the cream. Bring to a gentle simmer (small bubbles, not a rolling boil), stir often, 4 to 5 min until slightly thicker.
4. Turn heat to low. Add parmesan a handful at a time, stirring until each handful melts. Season with pepper and a little salt (parm is salty, taste first).
5. Add the drained tortellini and stir to coat. Too thick? Add pasta water or milk a splash at a time.

Sauce grainy? Heat was too high when the cheese went in. Keep it low and stir in a splash of cream or milk.

R10. Cheesy Garlic Bread

1 French bread loaf. Serves 2 to 4. 15 min.

Ingredients

- 1 French bread loaf
- 6 Tbsp softened butter
- 1 Tbsp wet minced garlic
- 1/2 tsp garlic powder, pinch of salt
- 2 Tbsp grated parmesan
- 1.5 cups GV shredded mozzarella

Steps

1. Preheat oven on Air Fry mode to 375°F.
2. Mix butter, wet garlic, garlic powder, salt, and parmesan.
3. Cut the loaf in half lengthwise (and in half across if it's long). Spread the butter mix to the edges.
4. Place cut side up on a foil-lined sheet pan. Bake 4 min to toast the butter in.
5. Top with mozzarella. Bake 4 to 6 min more, until the cheese is melted with golden spots and the edges are crisp. Watch it closely, this mode browns fast.
6. Cool 2 min, slice.

Save leftovers for Sat lunch: wrap in foil, fridge. Reheat in the oven (see Storage), not the microwave.

R11. Seasoned Chicken Breast (for gf)

Tyson fresh chicken breasts. 1 breast per serving. 25 to 30 min.

Ingredients

- 1 to 2 Tyson fresh chicken breasts
- 1 Tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp paprika, 1/2 tsp salt, 1/4 tsp pepper, 1/2 tsp Italian seasoning (or a dry rub she likes)

Steps

1. Preheat oven on Air Fry mode to 400°F. Foil-lined sheet pan, rack on top if you have one.
2. If a breast is very thick on one end, pound it to an even 3/4 inch (in a bag, with a pan bottom), or slice it in half horizontally. Even thickness = juicy chicken.
3. Pat dry, rub with oil, season both sides.
4. Cook 16 to 22 min, flipping halfway.
5. Done when the thickest part reads **165°F** and juices run clear. Rest 5 min before slicing.

Cook the whole pack if it's more than you need. Extra sliced chicken works on Saturday's potato bar or in a sandwich.

R12. Scrambled Eggs

2 to 3 eggs per person. 5 min.

1. Whisk eggs with 1 Tbsp whole milk per 2 eggs and a pinch of salt.
2. Melt 1 Tbsp butter in a nonstick skillet over medium-low.
3. Pour in eggs. Let sit 20 seconds, then slowly push from the edges to the center with a spatula. Keep going.
4. Pull off the heat while they still look slightly wet; they finish on the plate. Pepper to taste. Optional: a handful of shredded habanero jack in the last 30 seconds.

Timing for Sat breakfast: start hash browns (R2) and sausage (R13) in the oven first; eggs go last.

R13. Sausage Links (GV Vermont Maple)

One pack each for Sat and Sun breakfast. Check the package: if it says fully cooked, you are just heating them.

- **Oven (easy with hash browns):** Air Fry mode 400°F, foil-lined sheet pan, 10 to 14 min, turn halfway. Fits on the same rack or pan as the hash browns.
- **Skillet:** medium heat, splash of oil, 10 to 12 min, turning often, until browned all over.
- Done: browned and **160°F** inside if raw links.

R14. Kodiak Power Cakes (Joe's Way: Whole Milk and Eggs)

1 cup mix makes about 8 to 10 medium pancakes (about 2 servings). Double for two hungry people. Never water.

Ingredients (per 1 cup mix)

- 1 cup Kodiak Power Cakes buttermilk mix
- 1 egg
- About 3/4 to 1 cup whole milk
- Butter for the pan
- Real maple syrup for serving

Steps

1. Whisk the egg and 3/4 cup milk together. Stir in the mix until just combined. Lumps are fine.
2. Let sit 2 to 3 min (the batter thickens a little). Adjust: too thick to pour, add milk 1 Tbsp at a time up to 1 cup total. Too thin, a spoonful more mix.
3. Heat a skillet or griddle over medium. Light coat of butter.
4. Pour about 1/4 cup per pancake. Cook until bubbles form and edges look set, about 2 min.
5. Flip, cook 1 to 2 min more until golden. Turn heat down a notch if they brown before cooking through.
6. Serve with butter and real maple syrup, sausage links on the side.

R15. Baked Potatoes and the Potato Bar

Russet potatoes. Sat Oct 24: bake 4 (2 for dinner, 2 for Sun lunch). Nov 4: bake 1.

Oven method (best skin)

1. Preheat oven to 400°F (Bake mode; Air Fry mode at 400°F also works and runs a little faster).
2. Scrub, dry well, poke each potato 5 or 6 times with a fork. Rub with oil and coarse salt.
3. Place directly on the middle rack with a sheet pan on the rack below to catch drips.
4. Bake 50 to 65 min (Air Fry mode: about 45 to 55 min) depending on size.
5. Done when a fork slides in with no resistance and it gives when squeezed (with a mitt). Inside about 205 to 210°F.

Microwave shortcut

1. Scrub and poke all over. Microwave on a plate: 5 min for 1 potato, flip, then 2 to 4 min more. Add about 3 min per extra potato.
2. Done when soft when squeezed. Rest 2 min.
3. Want crispy skin? Rub with oil and salt, finish 8 to 10 min in the oven on Air Fry mode at 425°F.

Potato bar (Sat dinner, lighter style)

- Butter, Daisy sour cream
- Steamed broccoli (R16)
- Cheese: shredded mozzarella, shredded habanero jack, grated parmesan
- A small bowl of shredded chicken (R7), warmed with a splash of broth, on the side
- Optional: ranch, candied jalapenos, salt and pepper

Split the potato, fluff the inside with a fork, butter first, then toppings. Pop back in the microwave 20 to 30 sec to melt cheese if needed.

R16. Simple Sides: Broccoli and Corn

Frozen broccoli

- **Microwave (fastest):** 1 to 2 cups in a covered bowl with 2 Tbsp water, 4 to 6 min, stir halfway. Drain. Toss with butter, salt, garlic powder, optional parmesan.
- **Oven roasted (crispier):** Air Fry mode 425°F, toss frozen florets with 1 Tbsp oil, salt, garlic powder, single layer, 15 to 20 min, stir halfway. Done when edges are browned.

Frozen corn

- **Microwave:** 1 cup corn, 1 tsp butter, pinch salt, covered, 2 to 3 min, stir.
- **Skillet:** 1 Tbsp butter over medium-high, corn, salt, pepper, 5 to 6 min until a few kernels brown.

R17. Thick Pork Chops, Medium Rare (Cook 5, Freeze 4)

5 thick pork chops, thawed (move to fridge Fri night). About 1 hour.
Joe likes them medium rare: **pull at about 135°F, then rest.** (USDA guidance is 145°F with a 3 minute rest.)

Ingredients

- 5 thick pork chops, thawed
- Salt and your favorite pork rub (or garlic powder, pepper, paprika)
- 1 to 2 Tbsp vegetable oil, 1 Tbsp butter

Steps (reverse sear: even pink edge to edge)

1. Pat the chops very dry. Salt both sides and season. Best if done 30 to 60 min ahead and left uncovered in the fridge.
2. Preheat oven to 275°F, regular Bake mode. Chops on a rack over a foil-lined sheet pan.
3. Bake until the center of the thickest chop reads **120 to 125°F**, about 25 to 45 min depending on thickness. Start checking at 20 min.
4. Heat a skillet over high with the oil until it just starts to smoke. Sear 2 or 3 chops at a time, 60 to 90 seconds per side, until well browned. Add butter at the end for flavor.
5. **Pull at about 135°F.** For the 4 going in the freezer, pull them a little lower (about 130°F) since reheating adds a few degrees.
6. Rest 5 min. Eat 1 with corn (R16).

Oven-only option: Air Fry mode 400°F preheated, rack over sheet pan, 10 to 16 min, flip halfway, start checking at 8 min. Less even, still good.

Cool and freeze the other 4

1. Cool on the rack 20 to 30 min, then fridge uncovered until fully cold (about 1 hour). Get them in the fridge within 2 hours of cooking.
2. Wrap each chop tightly in plastic wrap or foil. Put all 4 in a freezer bag, squeeze out the air.
3. Label "Cooked pork chops, Oct 25." Best within 1 month, safe 2 to 3 months.

R18. Reheating a Frozen Pork Chop (Gentle, Stays Medium-ish)

Mon Oct 26 to Thu Oct 29. About 10 min. Low power is the whole trick.

1. Unwrap the chop. Put it on a microwave-safe plate with 1 Tbsp water or broth. Cover with a damp paper towel or a microwave cover.
2. **From frozen:** 30% power (or Defrost) for 4 min. Flip. 30% power 3 to 4 min more.
3. Check the center. Then 50% power in 1-minute bursts until warmed through, about **120 to 130°F** in the center for medium-ish.
4. Let it sit covered 2 min. Season with a little salt.

If thawed in the fridge overnight: skip the defrost step, 50% power 2 to 3 min, flip halfway. More even.
Even quicker and more even: slice the chop thin while partly frozen, then warm the slices at 50% power 1 to 2 min.
Food safety note: USDA recommends reheating leftovers to 165°F. Warming to about 120 to 130°F keeps it medium; that's your call.
Want a crust back? After microwaving, 45 sec per side in a very hot skillet with butter.

R19. Deli Sandwiches and Pack-Ahead Tips

Bunny bread (or a pretzel bun if extra). Hillshire turkey, pepperoni, hard salami.

Build ideas

- **Spicy turkey:** turkey, habanero jack slices, Duke's, spicy brown mustard, candied jalapenos.
- **Italian-ish:** salami, pepperoni, provolone, Duke's, a little spicy brown mustard.
- **Turkey and provolone:** turkey, provolone, Duke's, honey mustard.
- **The stack:** turkey, salami, pepperoni, habanero jack, Duke's, spicy brown mustard, candied jalapenos.
- **Hot version (if there's a microwave at work):** salami and pepperoni with provolone, 20 to 30 sec to melt.

Pack-ahead tips

- Pack the night before (or 2 days max ahead). Beyond that the bread gets soggy.
- Spread Duke's edge to edge on both slices of bread. The mayo acts as a moisture barrier. Mustard goes between the meat and cheese, not right on the bread.
- Cheese next to the bread on both sides, meat in the middle.
- Candied jalapenos: pack in a small container and add at lunch, or blot them dry on a paper towel before adding.
- Wrap tightly in plastic wrap or foil, then a bag. Keep cold: fridge at work, or an ice pack in a lunch bag.
- Add a side: a handful of Utz Pub Mix or Santitas chips.
- Open one lunchmeat pack at a time. Opened packs: 3 to 5 days. Smells off or slimy, toss it.

R20. Oven Hot Wings (GV Wing Sections)

GV frozen wing sections, thawed (fridge Thu night). Cook 2 lb (about 2 to 3 servings) or all 4 lb on 2 pans. About 50 min.

Ingredients (per 2 lb)

- 2 lb wing sections, thawed
- 1 Tbsp baking powder (optional, for crispier skin; baking powder, NOT baking soda)
- 1 tsp salt, 1 tsp garlic powder, 1/2 tsp pepper (or a dry rub)
- Sauce: Buffalo Wild Wings Honey BBQ, or homemade Buffalo (R8), about 1/2 cup
- Hidden Valley ranch and Marzetti blue cheese for dipping

Steps

1. Pat wings **very** dry with paper towels. Dry skin is what makes them crisp. (Extra credit: leave them uncovered on a rack in the fridge for a few hours.)
2. Toss with baking powder (if using), salt, garlic powder, pepper.
3. Preheat oven on Air Fry mode to 425°F. Wings on a rack over a foil-lined sheet pan, skin side up, not touching.
4. Cook 20 to 25 min. Flip.
5. Cook 15 to 25 min more until deep golden and the skin is crisp and crackly.
6. Internal temp at least 165°F; wings are best at **175 to 190°F** (more tender).
7. Warm the sauce a little. Toss hot wings in a big bowl with sauce. Do half Honey BBQ, half Buffalo if you want both.
8. Serve with ranch and blue cheese.

Cooking from frozen (forgot to thaw): Air Fry mode 400°F for 15 min, drain any water, pat dry, season, then 425°F 25 to 35 min, flipping halfway. Not as crisp.

R21. Pulled Pork Nachos with Pepper Jack

Serves 1 to 2. 15 min. Pork bag "Nov 1" thawed overnight.

Ingredients

- Santitas tortilla chips, about half a bag
- 1 to 1.5 cups pulled pork
- 1.5 cups shredded habanero jalapeno jack (pepper jack)
- Toppings: candied jalapenos, sour cream, BBQ sauce drizzle, ranch

Steps

1. Preheat oven on Air Fry mode to 375°F. Line a sheet pan with foil.
2. Warm the pork in the microwave, covered, with a splash of juice or water, 1 to 2 min.
3. Spread chips in a single, slightly overlapping layer. Scatter half the cheese, all the pork, then the rest of the cheese. (For more cheese in every bite, do 2 thinner layers.)
4. Bake 4 to 7 min until the cheese is melted and bubbly. Watch closely, chip edges burn fast in this mode.
5. Top with candied jalapenos, dollops of sour cream, and a drizzle of BBQ sauce. Eat right away.

R22. Skillet Burgers on Pretzel Buns

1 lb 80/20 ground beef, thawed. Makes 3 (1/3 lb) or 4 (1/4 lb) burgers. 20 min.

Ingredients

- 1 lb 80/20 ground beef
- Salt, pepper, garlic powder (or a burger rub)
- Habanero jack or provolone slices
- Pretzel buns, butter
- Toppings: Duke's, mustard (yellow, spicy brown, or honey), a little ketchup, BBQ sauce, candied jalapenos

Steps

1. Divide the beef. Shape patties about 3/4 inch thick, slightly wider than the bun. Press a shallow dent in the center with your thumb (stops puffing). Don't overwork the meat.
2. Season both sides right before cooking.
3. Start the hash browns (R2) in the oven first; they take longer.
4. Heat a skillet over medium-high with a little oil. Cook patties 4 min without moving. Flip.
5. Cook 3 to 4 min more. Add cheese in the last minute, cover the pan to melt.
6. Done at **160°F** in the center (no pink in the middle).
7. Wipe out most of the grease, butter the cut sides of the buns, toast in the skillet 30 to 60 seconds.
8. Build and serve with hash browns.

Leftover cooked patties: fridge 3 to 4 days, or freeze. Reheat in microwave at 50% power 1 to 2 min, or in a skillet.

R23. Buffalo Shredded Chicken Baked Potato

Serves 1. Chicken bag "Nov 4" thawed overnight. Microwave potato = 15 min; oven potato = about 1 hour.

1. Bake 1 large russet (R15). Microwave shortcut is fine for a work night.
2. Warm about 1 cup shredded chicken in the microwave, covered, 1 to 2 min. Toss with 2 to 3 Tbsp Buffalo sauce (R8).
3. Split the potato, fluff, add butter and salt.
4. Pile on the Buffalo chicken, top with shredded mozzarella or habanero jack.
5. Microwave 30 to 45 sec (or Air Fry mode 425°F for 3 to 5 min) to melt the cheese.
6. Top with sour cream and a drizzle of ranch or blue cheese. Optional: broccoli on the side (R16).

R24. 3-Cheese Chicken Skillet Bag Meal

1. Follow the bag directions (skillet, usually 10 to 15 min from frozen, stirring). Don't thaw first unless the bag says to.
2. Make sure it's steaming hot all the way through (165°F).
3. Optional add-ins: a handful of extra mozzarella or parmesan at the end, or a cup of frozen broccoli added with the bag contents to stretch it.

Storage, Freezing, and Reheating

Food	Fridge	Freezer	Reheat
Pulled pork	3 to 4 days	2 to 3 months, flat bags with juice	Thaw overnight. Microwave covered with a splash of juice, 50% power, stir every minute. Or skillet with a splash of water.
Shredded chicken	3 to 4 days	2 to 3 months	Same as pork; add a splash of broth (Better Than Bouillon + water) so it stays moist.
Cooked pork chops	3 to 4 days	Best within 1 month, wrapped individually	See R18. Low power, slow.
Tortellini alfredo	3 days	Not recommended (sauce separates)	Microwave at 50% power, 1 min at a time, stirring, with a splash of milk. Or skillet over low with milk.
Cheesy garlic bread	3 days, in foil	1 month, in foil	Oven 350°F, in foil 8 min, then open the foil 2 to 3 min to re-crisp. Microwave makes it chewy.
Baked potatoes	3 to 4 days (cool, then fridge; don't leave wrapped in foil at room temp)	Not great	Microwave 1.5 to 3 min, cut open halfway. Or oven 375°F 15 to 20 min for crisp skin.
Cooked wings (deli or homemade)	3 to 4 days	2 months	Air Fry mode 375°F, 8 to 12 min, flip once.
Cooked chicken breast	3 to 4 days	2 to 3 months	Slice, microwave 50% power with a splash of broth, covered.
Hot deli food from the store	Eat within 2 hours of pickup or refrigerate. Use leftovers within 3 to 4 days.		
Opened lunchmeat	3 to 5 days	Unopened packs freeze 1 to 2 months	Thaw in the fridge.
Raw ground beef	1 to 2 days	3 to 4 months	Thaw in fridge the night before.
Raw chicken breasts (fresh)	1 to 2 days (or by use-by date)	9 months	Thaw in fridge 1 day.

General rules: get cooked food into the fridge within 2 hours. Freeze flat in labeled bags (what + date). Thaw in the fridge, not on the counter. When in doubt, throw it out.